Own data or public data?

AP RESEARCH · CHOOSING A METHOD

Two roads can lead to evidence for your paper. This page does not change your question. Your question is the one in your log.

Ask first: does the evidence you need already exist? Spend twenty minutes looking before you decide to collect anything. Search the SDA archive, the Pew Research Center datasets, and Google Dataset Search. All three are in the Research Library.

A Road A · Collect your own data

Surveys, interviews, observations, or an experiment that **you** run with people.

Before you collect anything

1. Risk screen: who takes part, what they do, what could go wrong.
2. Consent form for adults. For anyone under 18: a guardian's permission **and** the student's own assent.
3. Data plan: where the data lives, who sees it, when you delete it.
4. Mr. Portela's approval of your proposal **and** every survey or interview question, with the date you may start. A College Board rule.

What you gain

- Data shaped to your question.
- A population you can reach: your school or community.

What it costs

- Review takes time. Ask Mr. Portela how long it takes this year, then count backward from your deadline.
- Small samples. You must say what a small sample cannot show.
- Limits. A study with more than minimal risk cannot be approved.
- To publish, compete, or present publicly, you also need a registered review board. Say so early.

B Road B · Analyze public data

Data someone else already collected and released, with every person's identity removed.

Before you analyze anything

1. Your risk screen still gets filled in. It records that your study has no human participants.
2. Read the codebook: the exact question people were asked, the answer choices, the years.
3. Save the file or table you export. It is your data file.
4. Record the dataset's name, release, and the date you used it.

What you gain

- Thousands of respondents instead of dozens.
- Change over time. The General Social Survey starts in 1972.
- No consent forms, because you contact no one.

What it costs

- You can only use the questions that were asked, in the words they were asked.
- The people surveyed may not be your population. The General Social Survey covers U.S. adults, not teenagers.

A third road: analyzing published texts or media, such as news articles, speeches, or advertisements. Texts are not participants. Posts by private people are different, so ask before using social media.

On every road: each number in your paper traces to your own file · you justify your method with a methods text you cite · you state what your data cannot show.

My decision today (it can change)